

Primary Source Reading 2: Rules as Compressed Experience

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From John Stuart Mill, Utilitarianism, Chapter II (1863) — text unaltered Read before Lesson 13b: The Principle of Utility and the Hedonist Calculus

Before you read: A natural objection to utilitarianism is that no one has time to calculate the effects of every action on everyone's happiness before acting. Mill's answer is not to abandon calculation but to relocate it — into the moral rules humanity has already worked out. As you read, notice the comparison Mill draws to a familiar religious objection, and watch for what he thinks moral rules actually are.

No Time to Calculate?

Again, defenders of utility often find themselves called upon to reply to such objections as this — that there is not time, previous to action, for calculating and weighing the effects of any line of conduct on the general happiness. This is exactly as if any one were to say that it is impossible to guide our conduct by Christianity, because there is not time, on every occasion on which anything has to be done, to read through the Old and New Testaments. The answer to the objection is, that there has been ample time, namely, the whole past duration of the human species. During all that time, mankind have been learning by experience the tendencies of actions; on which experience all the prudence, as well as all the morality of life, are dependent.

The Matter Is Already Done to Our Hand

People talk as if the commencement of this course of experience had hitherto been put off, and as if, at the moment when some man feels tempted to meddle with the property or life of another, he had to begin considering for the first time whether murder and theft are injurious to human happiness. Even then I do not think that he would find the question very puzzling; but, at all events, the matter is now done to his hand.

It is truly a whimsical supposition that, if mankind were agreed in considering utility to be the test of morality, they would remain without any agreement as to what is useful... mankind must by this time have acquired positive beliefs as to the effects of some actions on their happiness; and the beliefs which have thus come down are the rules of morality for the multitude, and for the philosopher until he has succeeded in finding better.

Improbable, But Not to Be Bypassed

That philosophers might easily do this, even now, on many subjects; that the received code of ethics is by no means of divine right; and that mankind have still much to learn as to the effects of actions on the general happiness, I admit, or rather, earnestly

maintain. The corollaries from the principle of utility, like the precepts of every practical art, admit of indefinite improvement, and, in a progressive state of the human mind, their improvement is perpetually going on.

But to consider the rules of morality as improvable, is one thing; to pass over the intermediate generalisations entirely, and endeavour to test each individual action directly by the first principle, is another.

After you read: Mill's move here is the seed of what later philosophers call rule utilitarianism, even though he never names it as such. Notice the tension he leaves unresolved at the very end: rules are useful precisely because they encode accumulated wisdom about what tends to produce happiness, but he also insists those rules remain open to revision whenever the underlying calculation changes. As you read the lesson, ask what should happen when following the rule and maximizing happiness in a particular case come apart — and whether Mill has really told us which one wins.